



Monumental feat: The 3-2 win against Australia was the Indian men's first win against the Aussies at the Olympics since a 3-1 win at the Munich Olympics in 1972. AP

Argentina, and Ireland — teams that can be unpredictable under pressure. Notably, New Zealand had knocked India out of the 2023 World Cup in the group stages through a shootout, but it wasn't unbeatable.

Compared to the later stages, it was easier for the team to bounce back from mistakes, regroup, iron out chinks and work out individual roles for the players. By the time India faced Belgium, it was already well-positioned to advance to the quarterfinals, having checked off the first goal on its list. The team was in sync, ready for a smooth progression.

Although India lost, it was its best performance till then. Less than 24 hours later, the players took to the field again, against perennial

nightmare Australia. That game, in more ways than one, was the ideal marker of the Indian team's real potential and possible finish in the Olympics.

The challenge was physical — back-to-back games against two of the fastest and toughest teams? Check. It was a mental test — could the team rebound from a narrow defeat? Check. Emotionally, it was a challenge too — would the players stay composed when facing the yellow-green spectre? A team that had crushed India 5-0 in a test series just three months earlier? Check. Tactically too, it was a test — could the team stick to its plan, resisting the lure of open spaces and the urge to revert to its natural attacking style? Check. Securing full points and a win against the Aussies felt like breaking a curse — India hadn't beaten them at the Olympics since 1972!

The game against Australia was the first sign that, despite its ranking (India was seventh before the Paris

Games), form, or expert opinions, this team had different plans. The momentum it built hinted that India might go all the way to the final, aiming for its first shot at gold since 1980. Even a contentious but legally correct red card, forcing it to play with 10 men for nearly 42 minutes against a fast-paced Great Britain in the quarterfinal, was just a minor setback.

"The red card revitalised us like nothing else. We decided we were not going to lose that game, come what may. We regrouped, defined our roles, worked out our plans, and just stuck to them. Any other game, not that one," was the chorus from the Indians after the famous shootout win.

A big criticism of the team at the World Cup was its visibly lower fitness level compared to Tokyo. Paris ended those doubts. It was also the game that brought the focus right back on Paddy Upton and Mike Horn, the duo credited with bringing in crucial mental toughness among